

ARTS

Chennai's Loyola College is No. 1 even as St. Joseph's College and Christ College from Bangalore, and Chennai's Madras Christian College debut at the Top 10

■ By Akhila Krishnamurthy

Last September, Loyola College had showcased its penchant for plays at an altogether different level. A group of students, essentially from Tamil literature, set a Guinness record by enacting a series of stories from *The Bible* for 72 hours, non-stop. Envisaged over a period of three years, the feat drew much applause, adding another feather in the cap of Loyola which has always nurtured a passion for the creative arts.

The 83-year-old institution, which has consistently figured among the toppers in the INDIA TODAY annual college survey, is the first-pick in the arts pack this time, up from the third position it had occupied in the last two years. This year, two Delhi-based colleges, St. Stephen's College and Lady Shri Ram College for Women, have also climbed higher to the second and third place, respectively, pushing last year's topper, St. Xavier's, Mumbai to the fourth slot. The other significant shifts in the arts stream as compared to last year include Bangalore's St. Joseph's College from No. 18 to No. 7 and Christ College from No. 12 to No. 8, and Chennai's Madras Christian College, which was not in the reckoning last year, to No. 9.

At Loyola, Father Albert Muthumalai, the principal, takes the results in his stride. "Our key differentiator is the emphasis we place on the overall development of students," he says. "In the first year, we concentrate on the personality of students, while the next year is dedicated to social awareness and social consciousness through the college's outreach programme wherein it is mandatory for students to clock in 60 hours helping the poor and the marginalised sections."

In the final year, students, who are singularly tuned into academics, plunge themselves into the industry with month-long internships. "It's an arduous task for us to ensure that

TOP 10 COLLEGES

	2007		2006
▲	1	Loyola College, Chennai	3
▲	2	St. Stephen's College, Delhi	5
▲	3	LSR College for Women, Delhi	4
▼	4	St. Xavier's College, Mumbai	1
▲	5	St. Xavier's College, Kolkata	6
▼	6	Presidency College, Kolkata	2
★	7	St. Joseph's College, Bangalore	18
★	8	Christ College, Bangalore	12
★	9	Madras Christian College, Chennai	-
▼	10	Presidency College, Chennai	7

National rankings are derived from a combination of perceptual and factual scores. Colleges that did not provide factual information were not ranked. ★: New entrants in Top 10. (▼) Not ranked in the 2006 Top 20.

nearly 2,000 students savour a slice of work-life between December 15 and January 15 every academic year," admits Muthumalai. But, he adds, these apprenticeships go a long way in exposing students to the realities of the world outside. To facilitate them are also events like the Loyola Expo, a platform for academy-industry interaction, organised with active participation from both students and faculty.

The gamut of course content covers a wide spectrum, ranging from history, economics, literature and sociology to niche studies in community development, human resource management, medical and psychiatric social work and human rights.

